

The Eligibility Snapshot: Process Description

Author: Chad King - MS Human Computer Interaction | Jarvis College of Computing and Digital Media | DePaul University

Executive Summary

The Eligibility Snapshot is a single-task intake flow that asks a veteran up to six categorical questions and returns a personalized housing benefit report. It collects no personally identifiable information and makes no eligibility determinations. Its purpose is to close a discovery gap: most veterans do not know which housing programs they may qualify for. The flow is therefore built to require zero prerequisite knowledge. A veteran who knows nothing beyond their own circumstances can complete it and leave with a concrete, ranked set of next steps, each tied to a named contact and a script for what to say.

1. Purpose and Problem Framing

The core problem this tool addresses is awareness, not navigation efficiency. Veterans frequently do not know what they qualify for, so a tool that optimizes the steps of an application a veteran has not yet discovered solves the wrong problem. The Eligibility Snapshot is designed for the moment before that: a veteran can state their situation in plain terms and receive an oriented starting point.

The flow is framed at entry with a single message: a veteran who does not know their VA housing benefits is invited to complete the Snapshot and find out. This framing sets the expectation that no prior knowledge is required and that the output is a starting point, not a verdict.

2. Design Principles

Three non-negotiable principles govern every decision in the flow.

No PII

The flow never asks for name, Social Security number, date of birth, full address, document photos, or medical details. If a veteran volunteers information of this kind, the assistant acknowledges it briefly and redirects rather than recording it. Every input the flow collects is categorical.

Zero prerequisite knowledge

Each question is written in plain language. Tooltips define terms a veteran may not recognize, most importantly the six discharge characterizations, so that a veteran does not need to understand VA terminology before answering. Where a veteran is unsure, an explicit option is provided, such as Unknown for discharge type and Prefer not to say for income.

Non-determination

The output surfaces likely pathways and concrete actions, but it never states that a veteran qualifies, is eligible, or is approved. Only the administering agency can determine eligibility. This principle is a matter of trust as much as accuracy: an eligibility misdiagnosis would do irreparable damage to a veteran's willingness to act, so the tool stays deliberately on the side of orientation rather than decision.

Voice

The assistant leads with the bottom line, stating the situation and the primary move before any supporting detail. The tone is direct, calm, and action-oriented, with military prowords used sparingly and no ranks or salutations. The intent is a report a veteran can act on, not a summary of what they just typed back at them.

3. Intake Sequence

The flow asks one question per screen, with no commentary between questions, and produces no output until the full sequence is complete. The questions are presented in the following order.

Question	Input options	What it captures
Q1 Discharge type	Honorable, General, OTH, BCD, Dishonorable, Unknown	The VA benefit eligibility tier
Q2 Housing status	Renting or Owner (Secure or At Risk), Temporary, Unhoused, Shelter or transitional	Housing stability and the single branch point
Q3 Conditional	Secure profiles: optional housing goal. All others: required urgency (tonight, 7 days, 30 days)	Direction for stable veterans, time pressure for the rest
Q4 Income band	\$0 through \$90,000+, or Prefer not to say	Income-based program signals
Q5 Dependents	Integer 0 to 20	Household size for income thresholds
Q6 VA disability rating	0% to 100% in 10-point steps, or Not Rated	Grants, exemptions, and healthcare enrollment signals

The conditional branch

Housing status is the only branch point in the flow. A veteran who is renting or owning and is secure is asked an optional goal question: keep housing stable, lower rent or mortgage burden, move to better housing, plan for homeownership, or other. The renter version reads “lower rent burden” and the owner version reads “lower mortgage burden,” because owners carry mortgage, tax, and insurance costs rather than rent. Every other housing status, including at-risk renters and owners, is asked a required urgency question instead: tonight, 7 days, or 30 days. Because Q3 branches, a veteran sees at most six questions on any single path.

The 0% versus Not Rated distinction

Q6 separates a 0% rating from Not Rated because the two describe materially different situations. A 0% rating means the VA has formally evaluated the veteran and some service connection exists on record, with VA healthcare access typically intact. Not Rated means the veteran has never filed a claim or has no decision on file, so VA healthcare enrollment is unknown. Since VA healthcare enrollment is a prerequisite for some housing programs, the distinction changes which next actions the report surfaces.

4. Output: Eight Sections

The report always returns the following eight sections, in this fixed order, with no truncation.

Section	Content
A BLUF	The bottom line: the veteran's situation and primary move, stated plainly
B Likely pathways	Up to three ranked programs from the Illinois label set
C Top next actions	Three to five steps, each naming who to contact and exactly what to say
D Document checklist	Two tiers, bring if you have it and likely required later, conditioned on tenure
E Disclaimers	Not a determination; agencies decide; no applications submitted
F Rationale	Three to six bullets explaining why each pathway surfaced
G Assumptions and unknowns	Three to six bullets naming what the Snapshot cannot determine
H Additional resources	Vetted partner slots mapped to the veteran's specific answers

Action format

Section C is held to a strict pattern: every action is a verb, a target, and a script for what to say or ask. An action that cannot name a specific contact does not appear. When an urgency window of 30 days or shorter was collected, the actions carry time-bound language and the urgency also appears in the BLUF.

Document checklist tiers

Section D adapts to tenure. At-risk owners and at-risk renters receive different document sets, reflecting that an owner facing foreclosure needs mortgage and tax records while a renter facing eviction needs the lease and any court notices. When coordinated entry is the top pathway, the checklist flags the DD-214 with an urgency note, since same-day access at a first appointment is faster with it in hand.

Additional resources

Section H is always last and always present. It maps resource slots to the veteran's answers, for example a discharge upgrade slot for less-than-honorable characterizations or an emergency housing slot for unhoused and sheltered veterans. Resource provider names and contact details are placeholders in the current build; a live partner directory is part of the a planned production roadmap.

5. Open Items

Two design gaps are recorded on the process flow and tracked openly rather than hidden. Round 1 usability testing, described in Section 8, now provides evidence behind them.

First, a **review screen** that lets veterans confirm and edit their answers before submission is not yet implemented. Round 1 user testing gave this direct support: a secure renter selected a primary goal, later realized it was wrong, and had to restart the entire flow to recover it, because the single-select goal question offers no way back. A confirm-and-edit screen would recover that veteran without a restart. The finding (F2) was rated high severity.

Second, **additional pathways for secure homeowners** need to be surfaced in the output: property tax relief and exemptions, disability housing grants (SAH and SHA), in-home care and support, and VA cash-out refinance. Round 1 did not test this directly, since the sessions skewed to secure renters and a single provider proxy, so it remains a flow annotation pending data from a Round 2 cohort that includes owners.

Candidates from Round 1 user testing not yet committed

During Round 1 user testing a subject S3, answering as a proxy for an unsheltered veteran client, proposed that the crisis branch route by age, surfacing youth and elderly emergency resources including non-VA options, to house someone the same night (F8, medium, candidate). A related higher-severity finding asks for operating hours and an open-now signal on crisis actions, noting that younger clients in particular will not check for themselves (F4). Both rest on a single provider session, the highest-stakes branch with the least data, and both are carried into Round 2 as re-test targets rather than committed changes.

An age branch would also require an input the Snapshot does not currently collect. Age is not among the six intake dimensions, so adding it would introduce a seventh question against the stated cap and would need a check against the no-PII principle, although an age band is categorical and likely acceptable. The proposal is sound in policy terms, since HUD counts youth 25 and younger as homeless under other federal statutes and Illinois carries youth-specific resources distinct from the adult veteran pathways, but the brevity and input-minimization tradeoffs are real and unresolved.

6. Generation

The collected answers are injected directly into a structured prompt. There is no retrieval layer in this path, an approach designated Path A. The prompt enforces a fixed output structure, a closed set of Illinois-specific pathway labels, and guardrail language. The Snapshot currently runs in a partner demonstration mode that always includes the rationale and assumptions sections described below.

Illinois pathway labels

The report ranks up to three pathways drawn from a fixed Illinois list, reflecting the Chicago feasibility pilot. The assistant may not invent pathways outside this set:

- Coordinated Entry (IL)
- VA Homeless Programs (IL), including HUD-VASH where it fits
- SSVF (IL), prevention and rapid rehousing
- Eviction Prevention and Legal Aid (IL)
- VA Loan Loss Mitigation and Homeowner Emergency Assistance (IL)
- Rental Assistance and Arrears Support (IL)
- Homeownership Readiness (IL) plus VA Home Loan basics

Routing logic

Housing status drives the primary ranking. For secure renters and owners, the optional goal sets the top pathway; a goal of planning for homeownership or moving, for example, routes to homeownership readiness, while keeping housing stable routes to eviction prevention and legal aid. For owners with higher income, SSVF is suppressed from the rankings and the report notes that income likely exceeds program thresholds. Income, dependents, and VA disability rating do not reorder the pathways. Instead they add specific, factual detail to the rationale and the assumptions sections, and in some cases a targeted next action, such as the Illinois Disabled Veterans Standard Homestead Exemption for rated owners.